

Life of a Civil War Soldier in the West Point Camps (1861–62)

What they ate, how they lived, and how they suffered

What They Ate (Hard Facts)

1. Standard Rations

Union soldiers at West Point received the same basic rations issued across the Army of the Ohio:

- **Hardtack** – a flour-and-water cracker so hard soldiers joked it could “stop a bullet.”
- **Salt pork or bacon** – heavily salted, often rancid.
- **Coffee** – the most prized ration; soldiers boiled it in tin cups.
- **Sugar** – small amounts, often traded or hoarded.
- **Beans or peas** – issued when available.
- **Molasses** – occasional treat.
- **Desiccated vegetables** – a compressed mix of dried cabbage, carrots, and turnips.

2. What They Actually Ate in West Point

Because West Point was a supply hub, soldiers sometimes had access to:

- **Fresh bread** from local bakers
- **Fresh beef** when herds passed through
- **Apples and potatoes** from Hardin County farms
- **River fish** caught in the Salt and Ohio Rivers

But these were **not guaranteed**. When supply wagons bogged down or weather turned bad, men went days on **hardtack and coffee alone**.

3. How They Cooked

- Each company had a **cook tent** (you asked about this earlier).
- Food was boiled in large kettles or fried in pans over open fires.
- Soldiers often cooked for themselves when the cooks were overwhelmed.
- Coffee was brewed constantly—sometimes three or four times a day.

How They Lived (Hard Facts)

1. Tents

Most soldiers lived in:

- **Sibley tents** (cone-shaped, held 12 men)
- **A-frame “dog tents”** (two-man shelters)
- **Hospital tents** for the sick

The West Point camps were **crowded**, with tents often only **3–4 feet apart**.

2. Bedding

- Straw when available
- Blankets issued by the quartermaster
- Many slept directly on the ground
- No mattresses, no cots, no insulation

3. Clothing

- Wool uniforms that stayed wet for days
- Worn-out shoes from marching
- Thin socks that offered little warmth
- No waterproof gear except gum blankets

4. Weather Conditions

The fall and winter of 1861–62 were:

- **Cold**
- **Wet**
- **Windy**
- **Muddy**

Pearman Hill was especially brutal—wind swept across the ridge, and the climb was steep and exhausting.

How They Suffered (Hard Facts)

1. Disease

The biggest killer in the West Point camps was **illness**, not combat.

Common diseases included:

- **Measles**
- **Pneumonia**
- **Typhoid fever**
- **Dysentery**
- **Chronic diarrhea**
- **“Camp fever”** (a mix of infections)

The 9th Michigan lost **dozens of men** during the construction of Fort Duffield—many buried in the cemetery near the fort.

2. Sanitation Problems

- Latrines were often dug too close to tents.
- Rain washed waste into camp areas.
- Water from the Salt River was sometimes contaminated.
- Garbage piles attracted rats and insects.

3. Exhaustion

Building Fort Duffield required:

- Cutting hundreds of trees
- Digging trenches
- Moving tons of earth
- Carrying logs up steep slopes
- Working from dawn to dusk

Soldiers wrote that the climb up Pearman Hill “took the breath from a strong man.”

4. Exposure

- Wet wool uniforms led to chills and pneumonia.
- Many soldiers lacked proper winter coats.
- Fires were hard to maintain in rain and wind.
- Tents leaked constantly.

5. Homesickness & Morale

Letters from the West Point camps describe:

- Missing family
- Fear of disease
- Boredom between work shifts
- Anxiety about Confederate movements
- Frustration with officers
- Pride in building the fort

Daily Routine (Fact-Based)

A typical day for a soldier in these camps:

- **5:00 AM** – Reveille
- **5:30 AM** – Roll call
- **6:00 AM** – Breakfast (hardtack, pork, coffee)
- **7:00 AM – 12:00 PM** – Work on fort / drill / guard duty
- **12:00 PM** – Dinner (beans, pork, coffee)
- **1:00 PM – 5:00 PM** – More work or drill
- **5:30 PM** – Supper
- **8:00 PM** – Tattoo (evening roll call)
- **9:00 PM** – Lights out

For the 9th Michigan, **fort construction** replaced most drill time.

Hardest Facts of All

- More soldiers died in the West Point camps from disease than from all Confederate action in the area.
- The steep climb to Fort Duffield was so exhausting that sick men often collapsed on the trail.
- Hardtack was sometimes so infested with weevils that soldiers joked it “walked off the plate.”
- Many men had never been away from home before; the camps were their first taste of hardship.
- Despite all this, the fort was completed in **less than two months**—a remarkable feat.